



NEIGHBORHOOD WATCH RANCHO PALOS VERDES

(Block Captain)

(E-Mail)

(Phone)

Dear Resident:

Your block is now a part of the Rancho Palos Verdes Neighborhood Watch program. Following is a summary of the program, what it does for you, and your role in making the program successful.

WHAT IS NEIGHBORHOOD WATCH? Neighborhood Watch is a proven and effective means of reducing crime. It is also the framework for our Emergency Preparedness program. The concept is based on neighbors working together with law enforcement to curtail crime. Over 90% of our city's single-family homes, as well as several multi-unit complexes, are in our organized citywide program resulting in a dramatic drop in crime in those areas. We have seen a measurable difference in crime rates between areas in an organized program, and those without such a program. This is because neighbors report all suspicious activities to the police, network all crime activity and mutually watch out for each other.

COMMUNICATION SYSTEM As a member of an organized Neighborhood Watch, your street is part of a citywide crime prevention network and warning system. An Area Coordinator liaisons with Neighborhood Watch, the Sheriff's Dept., and Block Captains. Crime warnings are e-mailed to Block Captains who, in turn, disseminate to Block Assistants and participating Neighborhood Watch residents. (In an emergency we will use phones.) This network is used in the following ways:

- To alert residents of current citywide crime activity and suspicious persons.
- To alert residents of crimes, suspicious or missing persons (or pets) in their own area.
- To alert residents of phone, Internet and other scams.

WHAT IS YOUR ROLE IN MAKING THE PROGRAM SUCCESSFUL?

- **GET TO KNOW YOUR NEIGHBORS** Your Block Captain makes up a list of the names, addresses and phone numbers of your neighbors. ***This information is optional and confidential and is never given out to anyone except perhaps your own neighbors. Neighborhood Watch e-mails only to Block Captains (blind). We do not want, or use other residents' e-mail numbers. However, it is important that you give your e-mail number to your Block Captain so he/she can forward the Crime Bulletins to you.*** We also encourage blocks to have yearly potlucks or get-togethers, and invite their deputies.
- **WATCH OUT FOR STRANGERS** Report any suspicious people that are parked in your area, driving around, or knocking on your door looking for someone else or asking for work. They may be casing your neighborhood to see who is home. ***Make a habit of writing down descriptions of suspicious people and cars, including license plates. If you have a feeling that something doesn't look right, please call 539-1661, your local Sheriff's Station, and ask them to investigate.***
- **PREVENT BURGLARIES AND ROBBERIES** Keep all doors, windows, and garage doors locked when you are not home. Burglars steal items from open garages in 30 seconds. Keep vehicles locked at ALL times and don't leave anything visible that you don't want stolen. Nearly all

residential burglaries occur during daytime hours after burglars check to see that you're not home. They can steal your jewelry even before an alarm company can respond. Hide jewelry outside of your bedroom. Engrave your California Driver's License number on electronic equipment, which better assures its return to you.

- **POLICY ON SOLICITORS** Under a recent Supreme Court ruling, anyone can solicit without a permit. However, under a City Code, solicitation is not allowed at any home where a DO NOT DISTURB or NO SOLICITING decal (available at City Hall or from your Block Captain) is displayed. You can call the Sheriff's Dept. on anyone that ignores the decal. Notify your Block Captain of all suspicious solicitors.
- **REPORT ALL CRIMES, NO MATTER HOW SMALL** Sheriff Dept. computers track crimes and criminals, even parts of license plates. Unreported crimes skew the real statistics and could result in your area receiving less patrol activity than it deserves. If crimes are not reported, neither deputies nor residents are going to be aware. ***After you notify the Sheriff's Dept. of a crime or a suspicious activity, notify your Block Captain so that he/she can alert the other neighbors. Quickly reporting and networking crimes facilitates faster apprehension.***
- **PETS AND PEOPLE** We will network members' lost or found pets, children and other missing residents through our Neighborhood Watch network. We do not use our network for political or commercial purposes.
- **IDENTITY THEFT** This is the fastest growing crime in our city. Never give out social security or other personal information over the phone, mail, or Internet. Shred all personal documents. Get a locking mailbox. Be alert for mail theft by using public mailboxes for outgoing mail and having a neighbor pick up your mail when you're gone. ***Never put the mailbox flag up!*** Many identity fraud cases start with theft of checks, bank statements and credit cards from mailboxes.
- **VACATION** Always notify a close neighbor or your Block Captain when you go on vacation.
- **SUPPORT YOUR BLOCK CAPTAIN AND ASSISTANTS** They are the life-blood of your Neighborhood Watch. Without them, the program dies and you will lose all contact with Neighborhood Watch and the Sheriff's Dept. Offer to help as a Block Assistant, and attend neighborhood activities. ***Remember, an effective neighborhood watch is one in which all neighbors contribute!***
- **WEBSITE** Check our website for information on scams, child abductions and other crimes: <http://home.netcom.com/~rpnw/>

Neighborhood Watch is managed by Volunteer Coordinators and volunteer Block Captains. The program is totally supported by periodic, voluntary, tax-deductible \$5 donations, which pay for the total cost of the program including signs, office supplies, newsletters and educational materials.

SUMMARY Building walls around our lives and our property hasn't given us more sense of safety or peace of mind. On the other hand, people in our city have learned that tearing down walls and building bridges of trust between neighbors and law enforcement has greatly added to their peace of mind and quality of life. ***After all is said and done, it is the community and our neighborhoods working together that have made the difference in the quality and safety of our lives. Please support Neighborhood Watch!***